

Brake Even

Product Brief · AI Builder Space Proseminar

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Brake Even is a mobile-friendly web app for the moment a driver gets a big repair quote and has to decide what to do. It weighs repairing, getting a second opinion, and replacing the car against the owner's actual cash, showing costs and assumptions instead of a verdict.

The Idea & The User

Brake Even is for anyone who has just received a big repair quote and has to decide, often that same day, what to do next. They enter the quote plus a few facts: car value, outstanding loan, available cash, how long they hoped to keep the car, and whether it's safe to drive. It then lays out three paths (repair now, get a second diagnosis or an independent-shop quote, or replace the car) with each one's upfront cash, approximate 12-month cost, and the assumptions that could change the answer, not a verdict.

It improves on existing repair-versus-replace calculators by centering the owner's cash on hand and willingness to spend. The idea comes from my own project cars: after repeated inflated dealership quotes, I learned to get the diagnosis, buy the parts, and do the work myself or bring it to an independent shop. Having worked at one, I see Brake Even as a Robin Hood play: moving business from overpriced dealer quotes to independent shops.

Does this exist already?

Yes. Fair-price estimators like RepairPal, Kelley Blue Book, and FairFix already check whether a quote is reasonable, and repair-versus-replace calculators exist too. The closest, repairoreplacecar.com, already factors in car value, the quote, loan payments, ownership timeline, and replacement budget, then gives a recommendation. CARFAX offers written guidance on the same decision.

I'm building Brake Even on purpose rather than because of a proven gap. It started as a school project, but mostly I want to learn how to build a tool like this, and it joins my love of cars with my dislike of overpriced markups. The angle I'm exploring is what I didn't find elsewhere: the owner's available cash, a second-opinion path, and an assumptions-based result instead of a verdict.

Scope for this sprint

With three weeks at one to three hours each Monday, the first version is a small mobile-friendly web app that turns one quote and a few answers into a side-by-side comparison. Photo upload, with AI reading the quote's line items, is a stretch goal if time allows.

Must-haves

- Manual entry of the repair quote
- A few questions: car value, outstanding loan, available cash, planned ownership time, and whether the shop says it's safe to drive
- Three paths side by side: repair now, get a second diagnosis or an independent-shop quote, or replace the car
- For each path: upfront cash needed versus cash available, and an approximate 12-month cost
- On-screen default assumptions for replacement and follow-on repair costs, which the user can edit
- The assumptions that could change the answer, plus facts to verify before approving work

Out of scope

- A “you can afford it” verdict
- Quote-fairness checks and OEM part links
- Local shop listings, referrals, or a repair marketplace
- A separate do-it-yourself path with its own cost math

Success

By the end of week three, I'll run real past quotes from my own project cars through Brake Even. A test passes if all three hold: the cost estimates land within about 15% of what I actually paid, the comparison supports the path I actually took, and I can finish the full flow on my phone in under five minutes. How many quotes I test depends on what I can find, which I've noted in Open Questions.

Open questions or risks

Longer term, I'd add quote-fairness checks with OEM part links, then shop referrals toward an open repair marketplace. That creates a tension: the no-verdict approach earns trust through neutrality, while a pro-independent-shop mission could look like steering. For the sprint, I still need to choose sources for the default replacement and follow-on repair costs, and find my past quotes to see how many I can test. With three to nine hours total, photo upload may not happen. Finally, whether people value seeing their available cash is untested, and my own quotes won't show whether less car-savvy users understand the results.